Lost&Found Telegram Bot — User Guide

1. Introduction

The Lost&Found Telegram bot helps university students and staff report lost items, announce found items, and coordinate the return of belongings.

The bot provides two main functions:

- **FOUND:** Report an item you have found.
- **LOST:** Report an item you have lost.

Reports are published in the university's Lost&Found Telegram announcement channel so that other users can see them.

2. How to Start the Bot

1. Open Telegram and navigate to the Lost&Found bot.
2. Press **Start** or send `/start`.
3. Read the welcome message and available instructions.
4. Choose **FOUND** or **LOST**, depending on your situation.

3. How to Report a Found Item

Use this process when you find an item that may belong to another student or staff member.

1. **Choose FOUND.** Start a new found-item report.
2. **Add a photo.** Upload a photo of the item if available, or skip this step.
3. **Describe the item.** Provide useful identifying details, such as the item type, colour, brand, or other visible characteristics.
4. **Select the location.** Choose the campus location where you found the item and enter the exact spot if requested.
5. **Specify the handoff arrangements.** Indicate whether you left the item where you found it, kept it for the owner, handed it to Student Affairs or security, or left it with another person.
6. **Choose a contact method.** Follow the bot's instructions for selecting how the owner can contact you.
7. **Review the report.** Check the description, location, and other information.
8. **Publish the report.** Confirm publication to the announcement channel.

Your announcement will be marked with `#FOUND`. Keep the item safe and follow the handoff arrangements you selected.

4. How to Report a Lost Item

Use this process when you have lost something on campus.

1. **Choose LOST.** Start a missing-item report.
2. **Describe the item.** Include its type, colour, brand, distinctive features, and any other useful identifying information.
3. **Enter the probable location.** Select the campus area where you think you lost the item and provide a more exact location if possible.
4. **Add a photo.** Upload a reference photo if available, or skip this step.
5. **Choose a contact method.** Follow the bot's instructions for selecting how someone who finds your item can reach you.
6. **Review the report.** Make sure all details are correct.
7. **Publish the report.** Confirm publication to the announcement channel.

Your announcement will be marked with `#LOST`. Check the channel for relevant `#FOUND` announcements as well.

5. How to Respond to a Report

If you think a found item belongs to you

1. Find the relevant `#FOUND` announcement in the channel.
2. Read the description and compare the item details.
3. Press **I think this is mine**.
4. Continue in the bot's private chat.
5. Choose the appropriate option, such as indicating that you have already recovered the item or that you want to contact the person who posted the report.
6. Answer the bot's questions and provide details that help identify the item. Do not rely only on information already visible in the public announcement.
7. Wait for the reporter to respond to your contact request.

The reporter can approve or decline sharing their contact information. If they approve, the bot shares the permitted contact details privately. If they decline, their contact details will not be shared.

If you find an item described in a LOST announcement

1. Find the relevant `#LOST` announcement.
2. Compare the description with the item you found.

3. Use the bot's available response or contact-request procedure.
4. Provide useful details about the item and where it was found.
5. Wait for the person who posted the report to respond and approve any requested contact sharing.
6. Arrange a safe return if the item is confirmed to belong to the person.

Do not publish another person's private contact information in the public channel.

6. Contact Privacy

- Contact requests should be handled through the bot's private chat.
- Contact details should only be shared according to the bot's contact-approval process.
- Avoid including sensitive personal information in public announcements.
- Provide enough item details to help verify ownership, but keep distinctive identifying details private when appropriate.

7. Returning an Item

When the owner and finder have been connected:

1. Confirm that the item matches the description.
2. Agree on a suitable return arrangement.
3. Follow the relevant campus handoff procedure.
4. Contact the administrator or Student Affairs if the item cannot be returned or the other person cannot be reached.

8. Tips for Effective Reports

- Use a clear, specific description.
- Include a photo when possible.
- Specify the exact campus location rather than only a general area.
- Check the report carefully before publishing.
- Respond promptly to contact requests.
- Treat other users' personal information respectfully.

9. Need Help?

If you cannot complete the process, cannot contact the other person, or need help returning an item, contact the Lost&Found administrator using the contact information provided in the bot's description.

Thank you for helping make the university community safer and more considerate by returning lost belongings to their owners.